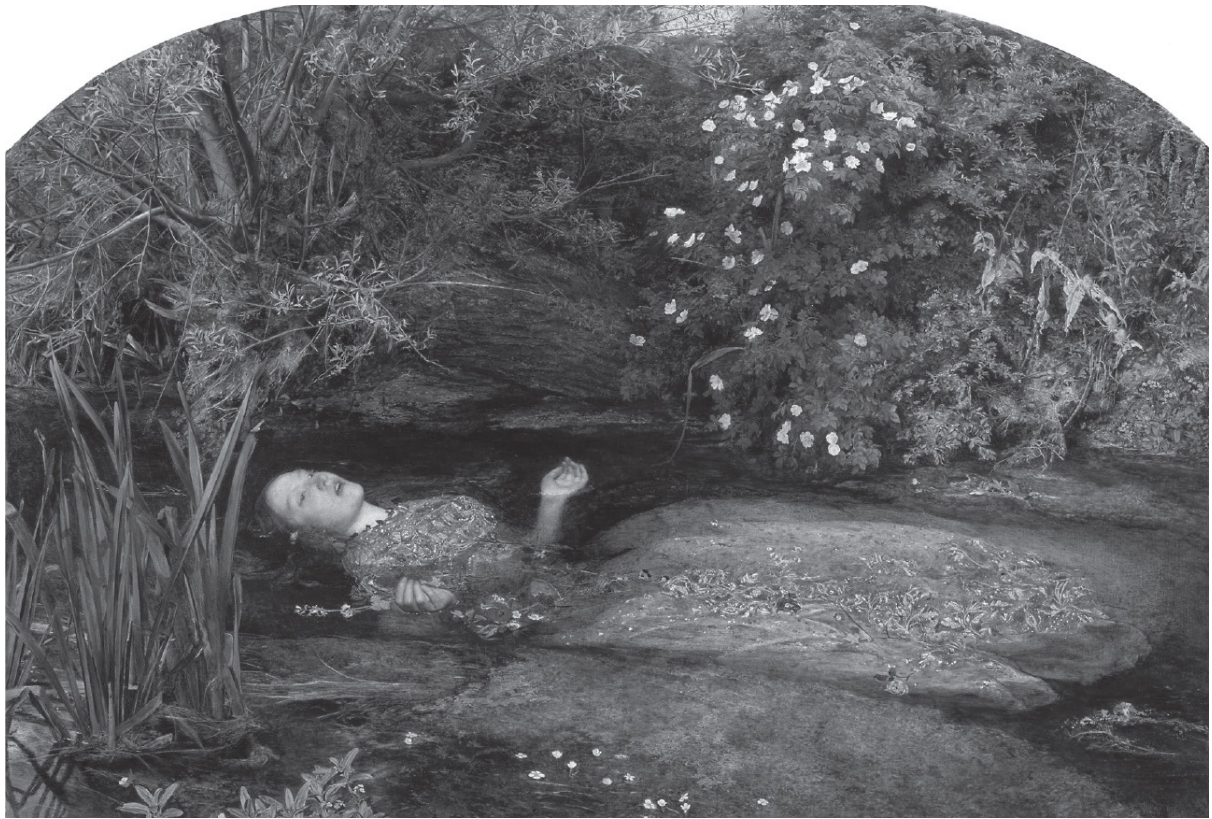


The Pre-Raphaelite Brotherhood

In 1848, a group of seven young English painters, poets and critics formed the Pre-Raphaelite Brotherhood, intending to return to painting in the uncomplicated styles practised in Italy before Raphael and Michelangelo. Rebelling against the artifice of Academic art, they painted realistically, using small brushstrokes and jewel-bright colours on wet, white grounds. They explored religion, literature, poetry and modern social problems, and they signed their paintings anonymously 'PRB'. The main members were William Holman Hunt (1827–1910), John Everett Millais (1829–96) and Dante Gabriel Rossetti (1828–82). Initially, PRB paintings were criticized for their disregard of academic ideals and apparently irreverent depictions of holy figures. But the leading art critic, John Ruskin (1819–1900), defended them and they became extremely successful. The group had dispersed by 1854, but a second phase occurred in the 1860s, led by Rossetti, Edward Burne-Jones (1833–98) and William Morris. Continuing to pursue PRB aims, the new group explored romantic symbolism and medieval legend.



Millais, *Ophelia*, 1851–2